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COL-501401

In most cases, darkness entails danger.

But not here.

Descending the darkened stairs, listening to the echoes of footsteps, approaching the door at the end of the passage, and hearing the faint conversation coming from inside.

It's the way home.

Sotheby: Ms. Sonetto, Ms. Sonetto! When will Vertin be back?

Sonetto: According to her itinerary, the Timekeeper will arrive at the Foundation in about 4 hours.

Sonetto: Mmm ...

Sonetto: Perhaps we still have the time to double-check ...

Sotheby: Check on what? Oh! Ms. Vertin's welcome-home gift?

Sotheby: Sotheby's "Soothing Sleepy Spray" is ready. Ms. Sotheby has checked and checked again! It will work perfectly!

She raises the atomizer into the air, sloshing the blue potion around inside.

The rustling of paper, the clattering of potion tubes, the fluttering questions with meticulous responses ...

Yes, this is home.

Choices

1. I'm back.

2. Soothing ... Sleepy ... Spray?

Branch 1

The door opens. Expectation tumbles into reality.

Sonetto: ...!

Branch 2

Sotheby: It will undoubtedly help Ms. Vertin freshen up, relieving her fatigue, and ...

Sotheby: Wait? That was not Ms. Sonetto!

Sotheby: That was ...

Shared continuation

Sonetto: Timekeeper!

Sotheby: Ms. Vertin!

Sotheby: You're back!

The green-dressed girl swoops towards Vertin from across the room.

Sotheby: I've missed you so very much, Vertin!

Sotheby: But you're home quicker than expected. You must have caught a ride on a very, very kind-hearted Hippogriff!

Sonetto: And the mission? We had wondered if everything worked out for you.

Vertin: It all went smoothly, and ahead of schedule.

Vertin: Everything all right on the home front?

Sonetto: Naturally. Thank you for asking. We ...

???: Vertin!!!

A booming voice shouts from behind.

Following the shout come hurried footsteps, a clanging cacophony coming from a cluttered bag, then a pair of arms, and a warm hug.

Regulus: Waah! You!

Regulus: You were gone for so, so, sooo long! You get into some trouble?

Vertin: Sorry. It was only a minor situation.

Regulus: Humph. Thought you were stuck in a real jam ... But this Pirate will forgive you. That's what friends do.

Regulus: And in return, this Pirate's friend will ask the Foundation for a double ration of Dr. Papper to show she's truly sorry for making her mates so worried.

Choices

1. Application sent.

2. Of course, that's what friends do.

Branch 1

Regulus: Mm? That was fast! When did the Foundation get so generous?

Regulus: Ah! I should have asked for more ...

Regulus: But then you'd have to file more paperwork just for this Pirate! Fine, consider yourself forgiven!

Branch 2

Regulus: Ooooh!! My best mate, most reliable of all friends!!!

Regulus: I can't imagine life without you ...

Shared continuation

Vertin: ...

With all worries and curiosities now set aside.

They huddle close together, and a new subject is found.

Sotheby: What is this? Oh! I've seen one of those before!

Sotheby: Ms. Sotheby sees something sparkling in Regulus's arms!

Regulus beams proudly as she opens her bag and pours its contents on the floor.

Regulus: Hah! I was wondering when you'd notice.

Sonetto: Bubble balls, Photosensitive paint, and ... Don't tell me these arcane gadget materials are from the Foundation warehouse ...

Vertin: Looks as though you've different ideas for how to use them.

Regulus: Heh heh! Well I'm not going to tell you now! It'll be something way more exciting than arcane gadgets.

Regulus: But that's not all I'll need! Come on mates, I could use a little help here ...

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COL-501402

Nightfall arrives in a most unusual way.

The expected soothing songs of evening have been replaced by blaring, restless rock & roll.

Regulus did not put a single piece of "borrowed" gear to waste. Reconstituting each element in her most imaginative way to breathe life into the party.

Regulus: Let's see those left hands! Now, the right hand! Aaaaand, let's rock!

It was, undoubtedly, a great party.

Druvis Ⅲ: *light chuckle*

A slender figure slips into the room.

Choices

1. Regulus seems to be having a grand time.

2. You look relieved to be here.

Branch 1

Druvis Ⅲ: She's ever the most energetic, noisy, and cheerful one.

Druvis Ⅲ: Strange as it may seem, the plants enjoy her.

Branch 2

Druvis Ⅲ: Plants are always drawn to warmth and light.

Druvis Ⅲ: They have enjoyed the night so far, and I as well.

Shared continuation

Druvis Ⅲ: Good evening to you, Ms. Vertin.

Vertin: And to you, Ms. Druvis.

Vertin: I'm very glad you came.

Druvis Ⅲ: I wouldn't have missed such a lively event.

Druvis Ⅲ: Besides, I brought something for you.

A branch stretches and blossoms in her palm.

The petals open up, turning into a familiar white flower.

Vertin: Is this ...

Druvis Ⅲ: You might recognize it.

She's right. You've seen this white flower elsewhere.

Vertin: A Rowan Branch?

Druvis gently strokes the white petals.

The flower is soft, gentle, and full of life.

Druvis Ⅲ: The night before your return, I heard this branch singing in the moonlight. I heard its cracklings, like the branch was stretching outward.

Druvis Ⅲ: This flower bloomed for you.

Vertin: Thank you. I will take good care of it.

Druvis Ⅲ: Someone is waiting for you just beyond the window near the woods.

Druvis Ⅲ: Go, Vertin. I should like to stay awhile. It's all very different to the banquets I was made to attend, and I like it. You've brought me no small joy. Thank you.

Sonetto: Oh, T, Timekeeper! Good evening.

Vertin: What are you doing out here all alone, Sonetto?

Sonetto: I ... Well, I shouldn't bother you with the reason.

Sonetto: Have the others given you their gifts?

Vertin: They did.

Vertin: Regulus gave me a disc "for safe keeping."

Vertin: Mr. APPLe apologized as he didn't possess any personal items to be given away, so he sang one of Regulus's favorite songs to make up for it.

Vertin: Lilya gave me a leather care kit for my suitcase, and X gave me a metal ball which he assures me "will come in handy one day."

Vertin: And of course, Sotheby and Ms. Druvis. Each gift was perfectly suited.

Sonetto: That's wonderful.

Sonetto: It's only that we were all very excited to see you again.

Sonetto: We cherish every moment we spend with you.

Vertin: I feel the same.

Vertin: Shall we go back inside? Regulus must have more prepared for us tonight.

Sonetto: Of course.

Sonetto: Just ... a moment please, Timekeeper.

Sonetto: I haven't given you ... my gift.

She hesitates for a brief moment, and takes out a white metal case.

It is light, sturdy, and easy to carry around—you are familiar with its shape and weight, I'm sure.

Vertin: Is this one of the Foundation's file cases?

Sonetto: Yes, and inside are records of my past missions.

Sonetto: As Timekeeper, you will encounter more dangerous and difficult missions in the future.

Sonetto: I've organized my past records in the hope that they could be useful for you in the future. Some of my solutions were ... far from meticulous, but I thought I ought to include everything so that you might steer clear of the same mistakes.

Sonetto: I, I didn't have the time to organize everything. It's just a part of all the past records. I don't know if it makes for a good present ...

Vertin: Thank you, Sonetto. I like it very much, and I will put it to good use.

Sonetto: ...!!

Sonetto: I'm so glad that I can be of help ...

Sonetto: Welcome home, Timekeeper.